

DESIGNER

CHARLES WORTH

Worth's reputation as the father of haute couture – designer-led, custom-fitted “high dressmaking” – was well earned. He dominated the Paris scene for the entire second half of the 19th century and made the city the couture capital. Shaping the high-end industry we know today, Worth led a general move in 19th-century Paris away from tailor-dressmakers towards designers whose creations bore their name.

An Englishman abroad

The initial irony was that Monsieur Worth was an Englishman. When family financial problems forced him out to work, he swapped his Lincolnshire home for an apprenticeship at London drapers Swan & Edgar at the age of 13. In 1845 he moved to Paris to Gagelin's, a dress accessories shop where he made a major mark, winning a medal for a stunning embroidered train at the 1855 Exposition Universelle in Paris. By 1858 he had established his own *maison* with business partner Otto Bobergh at 7 rue de la Paix.

Worth combined creative, impeccably fitted and made garments with astute business sense, especially the canny cultivation of an aura of exclusivity. With a discreet gilt sign outside, his *maison* featured a series of enticing salons, including a mirrored one with dressed wooden mannequins arranged so that customers would compare their own dress unfavourably.

Against the backdrop of the heady prosperity of Napoleon III's Second Empire (1852–1870), Worth's enterprise flourished. His wife's relentless networking helped. By the

1860s Pauline, Princess Metternich, the wife of the Austrian Ambassador to France was a customer. She introduced him to the fashionable French Empress Eugénie. It was a short step to securing her patronage.

Enduring values

Worth's creations included frothy ball gowns and outfits combining taffeta, velvet, and his beloved Lyons silk, with intricate detailing such as wooden beads wrapped in silk thread. Mid-century, his work featured the oversized crinolines for which the man and the era are so well known.

He pioneered the flat-fronted, bustle-backed skirt silhouette that took over after the empire fell in 1870.

Other innovations included a knee-length tunic worn over a long skirt, the shorter crinoline, ideal for walking, and the *gigot* sleeve popular in the late 1800s – one of many historical (in this case, Elizabethan) influences culled from National Gallery visits during his London years. Worth was first to show whole seasonal collections in advance, to use live mannequins to display garments, and to produce pieces that were copied in France and sold worldwide in addition to exclusive one-offs. Concerned about copyright issues, he pushed for the couture association that is still going today.

After his death in 1895, House of Worth and its values went forward under Charles Frederick's sons, Gaston-Lucien and Jean-Philippe, and beyond, taking in glamorous 1920s cocktail and evening dresses along the way before closing in the 1950s.

Worth's influence has been far-reaching, from Poiret to Bellville Sassoon to Valentino.

**△ VISITING CARD IN FANCY DRESS c.1860**

Worth had the gift of self-promotion and helped turn a trade into an art form. The first male style arbiter with international superstardom, his word was law. Customers deferred to him rather than the other way round.

◁ DEBUTANTE'S BALL DRESS

This satin gown with iridescent taffeta is decorated with silk roses and petals and accessorized with an ostrich fan. Worth's efficiency and talent with sumptuous materials made him equal to the task of producing the 1,000 or so lavish gowns that might be needed for just one imperial ball.

TIMELINE

1825 Charles Frederick Worth born in Bourne, Lincolnshire

○ 1820

1838 Starts apprenticeship at Swan & Edgar, London

1845 Takes work with London silk mercers Lewis & Allenby. Moves to Paris to work at dress accessories shop, Maison Gagelin

○ 1840

1851 His designs win prizes at London's Great Exhibition

1852 French Second Empire begins – an era of wealth and lavish dress

1857–58 Opens his own ladies' fashion business on the rue de la Paix

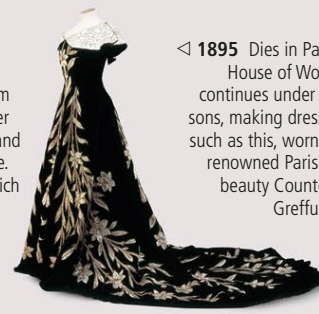


○ 1860

◁ 1860s A period of acclaim and success – creates all of Empress Eugénie's evening and state wear from 1864

1870 Second French Empire ends. Splits from business partner Otto Bobergh and continues alone. Prospers with rich American and Russian clients

○ 1880



◁ 1895 Dies in Paris; House of Worth continues under his sons, making dresses such as this, worn by renowned Parisian beauty Countess Greffulhe

○ 1895